Like A Fish to Water

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48446380.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Characters:
Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Abusive Parents, Homophobic Language, Suicide mention, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Alternate Universe - Summer Camp

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Like A Fish to Water

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

At Camp Bright Moon, Mermista is seen as cool, calm, and collected with a whole lot of snark thrown in for good measure. Outside of camp, her home life is a mess. Then Sea Hawk entered her life.

Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the work for more notes

Mista had been living with her father ever since she'd turned eighteen. He'd never really been around when she was a kid, just drifting in and out, but when she'd turned eighteen, her mother, who she'd never got along with anyway, had remarried. Between that, the new guy being a pain in the ass, and her father saying he needed help, she'd moved in with him. Her mother had immediately cut her out for supposedly choosing him over her. On top of that, living with him had been an unmitigated disaster.

Even though Mista was gone for most of the summer as a counselor at Camp Bright Moon, the other nine months out of the year she'd been living with him. He couldn't hold a job, losing job after job. He blamed it on his failing health but as far as she could tell, his failing health had pretty much everything to do with booze and really nothing else. She'd tried a few times to get him to realize but that had turned into ugly screaming arguments. Instead, Mista worked whatever jobs she could get her hands on and took care of him, or at least tried to do so.

She learned a lot of things from living with him.

Like when they got kicked out of an apartment because she had trusted him with the money to pay the rent and he'd given it to some friend he'd met at the bar a week before to invest in a llama ranch. That had never come to fruition, other than buying one llama that had been confiscated by animal control since you can't keep llamas in city parks just until you find a place for it. The lesson from that was she'd learned to give him a money order made out to the apartment or whatever utility needed paying.

When the money order got lost and they lost their electricity for a week until she could get it back on, she learned to just pay whatever bill it was herself. She learned that he might give her money for a share of the bills and rent and he might not but she knew not to ask. She definitely learned never to have cash on her because he would expect to get it. Then, when he almost got violent one night, she learned to always have a little bit of cash on her to hand over just to avoid the arguments.

In all of this, she thought about moving, she thought about trying to find a roommate, but the few people she was friends with from her non-camp work were either worse off than her or she knew couldn't be trusted. Her camp friends, well, she never mentioned any of her problems to them because it was her one refuge from it all.

The exception was Sea Hawk.

When she first met him, she found him incredibly annoying but she found she didn't want him to just completely disappear. They'd hang out and sometimes she'd grouch at him and he'd bow to her and leave, usually while saying something along the lines of, "I will leave you for now, my light! Fear not, it shall not be for long!"

She used to tell him that she wasn't afraid he wouldn't return but that he would. He'd laugh at that and go on. Then, over one summer, she'd found out that she actually was afraid of him not coming back. Maybe not afraid, she had told herself, but she found she actually missed the annoying twit when he wasn't around. She found herself wondering about him and what he was doing and found herself telling him things she hadn't told anyone

about before. It was so unlike anything she'd ever experienced and it confused her.

Mista had dated here and there before but it never lasted. Once out of high school, it'd all followed the same pattern. It would be a few heated weeks, or months at best, and then it'd all crash and burn. Every relationship had been like a fight for her. It'd been a constant struggle of strategies and tactics in dealing with the other person and she'd find herself burning the relationship to the ground half the time herself before it could get any further just from sheer exhaustion.

It wasn't like that with Sea Hawk. When she got pissed and shouted, he'd apologize if he'd overstepped. If it had been her fault, he'd let it pass and then softly ask for an apology after she'd calmed down. His apologies were corny but sincere and she found herself doing the same. More importantly, she found herself cutting herself off before she exploded or immediately correcting herself and apologizing. When she was with him, she wasn't constantly trying to analyze everything he said and she said to make sure it was the perfect optimum response to get exactly what she wanted. She was just herself in a way she didn't think she'd ever been before.

When Mista fell into love it was as easy as floating down a stream, so slow and gentle that she didn't even realize it until she was sitting with him on the dock at Camp Bright Moon one night, watching meteors streak across the August sky, and said without even thinking, "I love you."

"I love you too," Sea Hawk had said back, soft and quiet as he hugged her.

Mista had suddenly realized what she'd said and almost made a joke about it. Then she almost got defensive and pushed him. Then she realized it was true and the realization filled her soul like hot air lifting a balloon.

"I really do love you," Mista said as she sat up.

"I know you do. I really love you as well, my princess," Sea Hawk said.

"Why?" Mista said.

"Because when I think of myself, I think of you as well," Sea Hawk said. "There is no I without you and so I know I love you."

Mista started to say something sarcastic when she stopped and realized she felt the same way. No I without you. She got that. It was like she'd always been a whole person and now she was even more so, full to bursting, as if she'd float away if she didn't hang on to his hand.

"I… I want whatever this is to keep going," Mista said.

"I do as well," Sea Hawk said.

They kissed under the stars as streaks of fire dropped silently over their heads.

He left the next week when camp ended, to go on the road doing anything he could to travel, and Mista went home to her father. She didn't know it at the time but that was her last year at Camp Bright Moon. Her father took a turn for the worse, always bitching, never sober, and she couldn't leave him alone to go back for the summer and it went on that way for a little over a year and a half. She'd hear from her camp friends and feign indifference or a relaxed attitude but the only one who really heard her troubles was Sea Hawk. He'd come by but Mista never let him come to the apartment and she'd either meet him in the parking lot or meet him elsewhere.

Then, one night, she finally decided to have him meet her father. It'd been a cold and uncomfortable twenty minutes before Mista had quietly asked him to leave and she'd see him later. When he left, her father had rendered his judgment.

"What a worthless piece of shit. Why are you fucking around with that little faggot?"

"You need to shut the fuck up!" Mista said, her temper flaring brighter and hotter than it'd done in a long time.

"Don't you talk like that in my house!" he'd shouted back.

“It’s not your Goddamn house!” Mista replied. “You haven’t paid a dime towards rent on this shit hole in six months!”

The bottle streaked past her head and dented the sheetrock wall behind her. Mista didn’t flinch.

“You don’t get to talk to me like that! I’m the reason you’re in this world! Just because…” he started to say before she cut him off.

“Please, tell me all about how you took care of me and raised me!” Mista said with a bitter laugh. “You didn’t do shit! You cut and run before I even walked! I hardly ever saw you and the only reason I’ve been sticking around is some sick obligation to take care of you! Fuck you! You think you can do this on your own then do this on your own, you freeloading piece of shit!”

“You can’t judge me, you don’t know what I’ve been through! Besides, you think that little fairy you just brought home would do any better? Shit, is he some pity…,” he said and it was at that point Mista stepped nose to nose with him.

“Say one more thing about him and I’ll fucking kill you,” she said, her voice low and tight.

“Oh, tough girl, picking on her sick father,” he replied in a mocking voice.

“One more word. Fuck around and find out,” she said, her hands clenched tight.

Time stretched out taut for a moment as any horrible thing seemed possible.

Then her father turned away from her and stumbled to the kitchen to get a bottle and she turned and left the apartment to go find Sea Hawk. She stayed out almost to dawn with him, just venting as he quietly listened to everything she had to say. When she’d gone home, she’d insisted he not come anywhere near it and after they’d kissed good night, she’d gone up to the apartment to find the door cracked open.

She’d walked in to find what little stuff her father had gone. He’d written on the wall in Sharpie, “Guess you don’t have to worry about me being a freeloader any more.”

At first Mista tried to call him but the phone didn’t answer, then she panicked, assuming he was suicidal, and called the police but they were useless. They’d come out an hour after she’d called, taken a statement, and then said they’d keep an eye out while suggesting she call around to the local hospitals. By the time they’d got there though, she’d realized that her father probably hadn’t killed himself or had any intention of doing so based on things that were missing. He’d taken some medicine and clothes and most importantly, to him anyway, he’d taken every last bottle of alcohol in the place.

In the midst of her pacing around, trying to think of what to do when the police had left, Mista got a shock. She'd been keeping a bank account, not much of one but it held every dime she had in the world, and she happened to check it like she did every morning. It was empty except for a few dollars. It showed an ATM transaction she knew she hadn't made and when she went to look, she couldn't find her debit card. She stood in the middle of the cluttered apartment, with holes in the wall from where her father had rage punched them, and the old crappy furniture with the whole place smelling like stale cigarette smoke and dirty dishes and she cried. She didn't have money for food, she didn't have money for the rent that would be due in only days or the bills that were already past due, and so she just sat down on a chair and cried.

When her phone rang, she looked down and saw it was Sea Hawk and she almost let it go to voicemail but finally answered it.

"I hope I didn't wake you my dear Mista!"

She couldn't help but give a tired smile at his upbeat attitude.

"No, I haven't got to bed yet," she said, holding back her tears.

"Oh, well I have fantastic news! Remember that guy I told you I met? The one with the boat he needed crewed?" Sea Hawk said and then went on without waiting for a response. "He called and said that I could do it for him!"

Mista remembered what he was talking about. Some rich guy that Sea Hawk had said he'd met and how he wanted Sea Hawk to supposedly sail some sailboat from a harbor in Mississippi to the Florida Keys. Sea Hawk swore he had the knowledge to cross the Gulf of Mexico when Mista had asked him about it, half laughing, but Mista figured even if he did it was still probably just some guy screwing with Sea Hawk. Now she just wiped at her tears as she said, "That's great. I'm happy for you."

She could hear Sea Hawk on the other end go quiet for a moment before he said, "Are you alright?"

Mista almost said yes, just to not burden him, but then she found herself saying, "No. My father left and took all my money. I don't even know how I'm going to get to work this afternoon."

Sea Hawk responded immediately.

"Come with me."

"What?"

"I can't go alone anyway and I can teach you whatever you need to know. Come with me."

Mista thought of a thousand reasons to say no in an instant before she answered.

“Come get me.”

“I’ll be there in ten minutes.”

Mista pulled down an old green canvas duffle from her closet and went through her stuff, packing clothes she knew would last. She packed up her toiletries and shoved a couple of granola bars, all that was really left in the kitchen, into the bag. It took Sea Hawk fifteen minutes to get to the apartment and he walked in as she took a small photo album with pictures of her friends from Camp Bright Moon, as well as a few mementos stuffed in with it, and put it into the top of the bag before closing it up and throwing the strap over her shoulder. She kissed him, shut the door, walked to the apartment office, and tossed the key on the counter.

“Apartment 127, checking out. It’d have been yours in a few weeks anyway,” she said and then walked out as the woman who worked in the office followed her sputtering and asking what in the world she was talking about. The woman was still sputtering when Mista climbed on the back of the scooter that Sea Hawk had got from somewhere, strapped on the helmet he handed her, and then puttered out of the parking lot. She could almost feel the flames of the bridge she’d just torched behind her licking at her back. It felt warm and comforting.

The drive from her apartment to Long Beach, Mississippi, where the sailboat was located, would have taken about thirteen hours by car, basically one long day of driving. They didn’t have a car though. By old scooter, one that didn’t want to go over sixty and

even then wasn't quiet about it, it took them two days and one night.

They'd stopped multiple times to let the scooter cool off and at one point Mista was sure they were screwed when it'd stopped running along some back highway in east Texas. She'd crouched beside Sea Hawk under soaring pine trees as he'd tinkered with the engine for about an hour with a beat up multi-tool before it'd sputtered to life. She let out a long breath she hadn't been aware she was holding and got back on, offering up a prayer to whoever was listening that the old thing would hold out just long enough.

That night Mista spent the last of her money on a couple of sodas and a burger they split at an all night fast food place in a gas station. They'd taken turns staying awake in a booth so people would take less notice of them. Sea Hawk had managed to be charming enough that the manager of the place had left them alone but they'd still moved on before the sunrise, and the next shift, had come.

Mista had always loved water and had often dreamed of the ocean but she'd barely even left the landlocked state she'd grown up in. Even then it'd only been to neighboring states, those landlocked as well, and not very far even then. She'd sat on the beach at lakes and tried to imagine what it would be like to see nothing but water stretching out before her and not just the other side of the lake. She'd swam in rivers, feeling their pull, and thought of strong currents in the ocean. She was a woman missing from her natural element and the closer she got to the Gulf, the more she began to really realize that.

The scooter had been making a bad noise ever since they'd crossed the Mississippi state line from Louisiana and neither one had been willing to say what was on their mind. They were too close to their destination to voice anything that might screw it all up. Still, as they came over a bridge in Bay St. Louis, it started to die for good but Mista didn't even notice it as it lost power. She was staring wide eyed through the dirty screen of her helmet at the Gulf of Mexico sprawled out all the way to the horizon.

The scooter began to sputter and clank as they rolled out of sight of the Gulf for a moment and then it caught a little more power as they went down the bridge and came around a curve in the road. There, stretching out in front of them along the little highway, was a long strand of white sand beach. It'd been winter back at the apartment but here it was still warm, like a spring day to Mista. After a few more miles, with the scooter smoking and jerking the whole way, they'd passed a sign telling them they were now in Long Beach.

Sea Hawk pulled over into a small parking lot right on the beach and the scooter died a quiet death, smoke drifting out from the engine. He turned and said something but Mista didn't hear him. She climbed off the scooter and pulled her helmet off, the breeze from the ocean flicking through her hair as she stepped down the little sea wall between the parking lot and the beach.

Sea Hawk watched her quietly as she walked across the sand. Mista marveled at the softness of it, how she slid a little with each step before the sand compacted enough to let her take a stride, but her eyes were transfixed on the waves rolling into the beach in a light swell as the helmet dropped from her hands and hit the beach. Her coat, a prized possession with patches and hand stitches all through the denim, was next to be discarded without a

thought. Then her shoes, then her socks, and then she was walking into the water without a pause as a sea gull swung overhead, cawing as if in greeting to her. It was low tide and she didn't stop walking for almost a hundred yards, never getting deeper than her knees, when a wave hit her and splashed up, soaking her. She started laughing as she felt like every care and worry she ever had was being washed away and she spread her arms out as she fell backwards into the surf, still laughing even as her head went under and the waves rocked her like a child in her mother's arms.

Several hours later, right before sundown, Mista and Sea Hawk walked into the local marina with everything they owned in the world over their shoulders, having left the keys in the scooter to whoever would have it. Sea Hawk went right up to the harbormaster and talked with her for a few minutes before coming back with the keys to the boat slip. They got on board the little twenty-seven foot sailboat and looked it over as Sea Hawk kept up a running instruction on everything they were seeing. It took a day to get it provisioned, using the owner's charge account with the marina per the agreement Sea Hawk had made, and to get Mista up to rudimentary speed on what they were about to do.

Then, the next morning as the tide was high, they moved out of the slip under motor and headed out to sea. When they were several miles offshore, they stopped the motors, raised the sails, and with a whump as they caught the wind the ship heeled over a little and they started their six hundred mile crossing of the Gulf towards the Florida Keys. As the land slipped below the horizon behind them, Mista held the tiller of the boat in one hand and Sea Hawk's hand in the other, never looking back as her eyes were full of the open ocean in front of them as her heart sang.

End Notes

This came to me when I was driving to Mississippi on my anniversary trip. My wife had never seen the ocean before and part of this is inspired by her first meeting with the Gulf of Mexico. I've said before that places in these fics have real world counterparts, though they might not be one-to-one. The place where Mista put her feet on the beach for the first time? It is one-to-one from where my wife did as well.

I didn't name Mista's father because as far as I can remember, he's never named in the series. I preferred to keep him unnamed here as well. He doesn't have a name, he doesn't need a name.

This one came out in one long writing session. I was working on the end of The Summer After and I kind of hit a bit of a hitch and wasn't feeling it and I thought, "You know, I can write a little bit of this one." I should know better. Any time I say that, I end up writing the whole thing all in one go or at the very least, a huge chunk of something. This was the same thing. Also, when I edited this, I realized that I've ended up with the fic version of Fast Car by Tracy Chapman.

I've honestly been really looking forward to posting this one. I hope you enjoyed it and as always, thank you so much for reading.

Edit: Realized I had a photo of where Mista put her foot down on the sand for the first time.



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